

NEWSLETTER



PPG Industries

Summary of the talk



On November 5, Mr. Patrick Thong from PPG's SAP Center of Excellence shared how PPG, a global leader in paints and coatings, uses SAP ERP to manage its worldwide operations. He explained that SAP creates a single source of truth by integrating key functions such as finance, supply chain, production, and sales. The talk also highlighted PPG's 30-year SAP journey, from its first adoption in 1991 to the current migration to SAP S/4HANA. Mr Patrick introduced the core processes like 'Procure to Pay' and 'Order to Cash', showing how SAP connects every business step. The session ended with insights into SAP career opportunities, emphasizing its global demand and strong job stability.

Technologies and Issues Discussed

The industrial talk provided a comprehensive overview of the key technologies and challenges in enterprise system management, centered on the theme of Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP). The speaker, Mr. Patrick Thong, identified SAP (SystemAnalyse Programmentwicklung) as the specific ERP software PPG utilizes to unify its core business processes and establish a single source of truth. He elaborated on SAP's modular structure, which is categorized into Functional modules for business operations like Sales & Distribution (SD), Materials Management (MM), and Finance (FICO) ; Technical modules such as BASIS and ABAP for backend architecture management ; and Reporting modules like Business Warehouse (BW) and SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC) for data analysis. A significant theme was technological evolution, illustrated by PPG's own implementation history from its R/2 system in 1991 to its current migration towards the modern, cloud-based SAP S/4HANA and Amazon Web Services (AWS). This evolution presents two major challenges. The first is the inherent integration complexity of connecting numerous, distinct business streams, such as Procure to Pay (PTP), Demand to Replenish (DTR), and Order to Cash (OTC), into one seamless system . The second is the significant logistical challenge of global-scale collaboration required to manage this unified system across PPG's operations in over 70 countries.

Reflection: Lau Yee Wen

This talk was a crucial bridge, connecting our course theory to real-world practice. Mr. Thong's presentation demonstrated that enterprise systems are not static tools but evolving, long-term strategic assets. The session significantly increased my interest in this field, especially after learning about the high demand for SAP professionals and the diverse career paths available. His advice during the Q&A was also motivated me a lot, his emphasis on an intern's passion for learning and honesty was both practical and encouraging, clarifying what is valued beyond just technical skills.

Reflection: Cheryl Cheong Kah Voon

From the talk, I gained a clearer understanding of how ERP and SAP systems help companies like PPG manage global operations efficiently. I learned that SAP integrates core functions such as finance, supply chain, and production into one unified platform, improving accuracy and decision-making. The discussion on PPG's migration to SAP S/4HANA highlighted the importance of continuous digital transformation. I also discovered that SAP skills are highly valued and offer strong career prospects. Overall, the session inspired me to explore ERP systems further and consider building a career in this growing field.